



Music on the move

So many MP3 players and PMPs in the market. How do you choose?

Recently, someone in the Digit team lost the ability to play music on the go, when the audio jack on his Nokia 3500c stopped functioning. Yes you heard that right, he still owns that ancient relic of a phone the Nokia 3500c! Now you know why I'm not revealing this person's name. Let's save the poor bloke some embarrassment right?

First up I decided to go to my favourite haunt for tech products - Lamington road. Here I was sure to find not only branded players from the likes of Sony, Philips, and Creative, but also hoards of those Chinese unbranded devices. The reason I'm curious about these is because every now and then you do find a gem even in the unbranded space.

The prospective budget 'Mr. Ancient Phone' gave me was a generous Rs. 6,000. This opened up my choices by a considerable margin. There were little shuffle-like mp3 players with no screen, players with 3 to 4 line LCD/LED screens, and then finally colour display PMPs with screen sizes of one inch and above.

The MuVo T200 4 GB was available for Rs. 2,800. Now the shop keeper was quick to point out the sticker on the box that said upto 2000 songs. "This does the work of 8 GB" he said. Now before I could wonder whether the player used some highly advanced

compression technique on the flash memory itself, I found out that there was a caveat - *Approx. 4mins per song at 64kbps WMA. "Ah no wonder", I thought. And here the shopkeeper was trying to give me a load of hogwash. The 2GB version was available for Rs. 2,400. I wasn't too impressed with this player though.

The next shop I went to showed me an interesting player. It was an almost exact replica of the Apple Nano, but with a price tag of Rs. 3,600 for 8 GB. The player was from a company called Gemini. I looked at it with a fair amount of disdain and struck up a conversation with the shop owner about cheap ass Chinese rip offs and how they stop functioning the moment you walk out of the store. Much to my surprise he said "The player comes with a one year warranty, so it's not strictly a nameless Chinese product. There's nothing technically wrong with the device, just don't drop it and it'll last you well". Hmm easier said than done. But apart from that it was commendable how perfectly it nailed the Apple design, right from the interface to the touch sensitive scroll wheel.

While browsing though some shops I also got a chance to operate a couple of mp4 players with rather large screens (3 inches +) from a company called JXD. Now

these things also had a 2.0 MP Camera. The interface was rather crappy with both Chinese (or Japanese I couldn't tell) and English menus. The build quality of these devices - all in the range of Rs. 2,600 to Rs. 2,900 - was abysmal. It felt like you could literally crush the device by accident if you held it too tight.

This was a problem I faced with most players. But as buyers what you can do is look at a couple of aspects. Bass level - is it too boomy? Check the output level - is it loud enough? And lastly check whether it distorts.

In the course of the shopping session I saw several players. There was a Sansa 8 GB for Rs. 5,500. A Sony Walkman Eseries (NWZ-E443) for Rs. 4,500 which had FM, a 2 inch display and a capacity of 4GB - not a bad price point considering it's a player from Sony. A Samsung 8 GB player that caught my eye was the YP-Q1. It had touch sensitive keys, 2.4 inch screen and a very lively interface for Rs. 5,200. In this range the Philips Aria 4GB was good too with a 2 inch screen and video capability. Note however that most of these players require you to transcode video using the bundled software. Speaking of Philips, I found the whole Vibe series to be pretty useless with a 1.5 inch screen and with buttons that feel really cheap. What's the point of such a small screen? You can't really enjoy video on it.

So now it's decision time. For my friend with a budget of Rs. 6,000 I'd recommend the easy to use Philips Aria which is available for Rs. 5,000 and comes with noise cancellation earbuds. For those of you who want to take a chance with the Nano replica, the Gemini one is not a bad option for Rs. 3,600 considering there's a warranty on it. For a basic MP3 player with an LCD screen I think the Moserbear MP565 2GB for Rs. 1,500 is a good value option. It's got FM and a decent interface. In terms of sound it was loud enough and when better earphones were plugged in, it sounded even better. For audiophiles on the go who refuse to listen to anything other than uncompressed audio, for

Rs. 2,500 the iAudio E2 is a good option as it plays a wide variety of file formats including FLAC. 

